with no endgame in sight. They build large portfolios but remain trapped on the standard path.

Carson feels fortunate to have learned this valuable lesson early as a real estate investor. He said, “Some of the best mentors I’ve had in real estate said just keep it simple. Buy a house a year for five years and make each deal better than the last one. Don’t try to be fancy. Don’t try to be crazy. Just try to do the fundamentals really, really well.” This idea of aggregating marginal gains is certainly not foreign to those who *Choose FI*. This mindset has allowed Carson to consistently make better deals, focusing on strategies he’s most comfortable with and has found to be successful.

The simple strategy of gradually accumulating properties has been effective for others in the FI community. One example is Scott Trench, author of *Set for Life* and co-host of the podcast *BiggerPockets Money.* On the *ChooseFI* podcast, he told Brad and Jonathan that he bought his first investment property, a duplex, as a “house hack” in fall 2014. He repeated the process, moving into a second duplex. He then purchased a quadplex the next time. Throughout the process, he was able to get favorable owner-occupied financing and a cheap or free place to live. These purchases gave him seven rental units plus a place to live at the end